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University 102 is the second class I have taken at Duke focused on the climate and environment. While I've always been in favor of climate activism and limiting the effects of climate change, classes at Duke have shifted my focus drastically. Before, my thoughts revolved around being a personal steward in daily life with actions that conserve water and energy or reduce my carbon footprint. This has certainly not changed, but now I think much more deeply about my future actions within business and my career.

I aspire to run my own company one day, as many Duke students do. Before Duke and this class, I felt that my ability to affect climate change was insignificant and to an extent it is. I have realized, however, that I can extend my impact much further by translating it to the business sphere as well. I often think about how I can grow a future business sustainably and perhaps even have one focused on climate-positive work. For example, I've developed an interest in renewable energy infrastructure and the policy behind its buildout.

In the other environmental science class that I've taken at Duke, we watched a documentary about Sasol, one of the world's biggest chemical companies and their tremendous atmospheric and environmental pollution. I remember being saddened by the documentary, but ultimately forgot about it until I was driving through Louisiana en route to my internship that summer. I looked out my window and saw the exact plant which had been featured in the documentary and was quite shocked because I doubted many of the people in neighboring towns had any idea about the harm they were doing.

I reference this because it was one of the first times that I had felt anxiety and hopelessness about climate change. Our class with Valerie Sabol on addressing climate change

and mental health opened my eyes to the fact that others feel similarly. Perhaps even more importantly, there's infrastructure already in place that can help folks overcome climate anxiety. I had never given thought to that fact that hopelessness can limit the actions of those most in favor of protecting the climate because they think it doesn't matter. I now know that there can be tangible benefits to opening up about climate anxiety and that it can help society progress.

Ironically, my internship that I had been driving to that summer was also at XXXXXXXXXX, one of the biggest energy companies on Earth and the culprit of environmental disasters like XXXXXXXXXXXX. While I never had an intention to return past the summer internship, I still felt guilt about working for such a company. What I found, however, was pretty shocking.

I saw that BP is one of the most progressive energy companies among the giants like ExxonMobil, Shell, and Conoco Philips. They have made efforts to decarbonize and shift future investment into renewables on a scale unprecedented in the industry. The employees there are also huge proponents of protecting the climate but possess a healthy dose of realism that it can't happen overnight.

This experience allows me to understand debates about reliance on oil and natural gas with far greater depth. Our class with Dan Vermeer didn't necessarily change my worldview, but certainly fell within my wheelhouse and confirmed much of what I already think. Many activists don't realize that the economics of decarbonization are as important, if not more so, than the technological or scientific advancements. Dan Vermeer talked about incentives and that change takes time, all of which was reassuring that there are those working on climate change who understand the economic issues.

Subsequently, I feel that one large takeaway from the different interviewees is that most experts appear somewhat pigeon-holed in their own field, but in reality must work with dozens of other groups to enact change. For example, the media, economists, policy makers, scientists, publishers, businesspeople, researchers, and many groups must work together to make progress. I saw that most of the interviewees mention these other groups frequently which demonstrated the cooperation already taking place. While this doesn't make me feel more or less anxious about the issue itself, I do feel more confident in society's ability to have a fighting chance.

Another class which was impactful to me was the discussion of the Great Salt Lake by Amy Schmid. When I think of ongoing environmental disasters, it tends to be in third world countries or undeveloped regions. To know that one of the largest disasters is currently happening in Utah is both surprising and disappointing. Americans should already be aware of the effects of large bodies of water being drained after the toxic dustbowls arising from situations like Owens Lake in California. In retrospect, I'm glad the class was included for a few reasons. First, much of our time is spent discussing past disasters or the future, but rarely do we see examples in the present and it helps us visualize the issue as something current. Second, we have also spent a lot of time discussing the hope that technology and researchers provide, but a dose of realism can be healthy especially since it's occurring in our own backyard. Finally, it made us think about potential solutions to the issue from the lenses of policy, economics, and science.

Switching gears, I want to reflect upon the benefit of simply how many backgrounds the interviewees came from. It goes without saying that the diversity of expertise was tremendous. I think the benefit in this, at least for myself, is that different formats appeal to different aspects of myself. This could, of course, also be valuable in that it may help people who are disinterested with one interview resonate deeply with another. In my experience, I was able to grow much

more than in a lecture-based class because the different interviews showed me the argument from so many angles. I was able to consider both the problem and potential solutions from sides which have simply never occurred to me before.

Ultimately, I'm glad that I took the course and I find value in the format. I think that the inclusion of small group time each day allowed the conversation to broaden and perhaps for more inner opinions to come out. Our small group was not hesitant to share when we disagreed with an interviewee's comment, and this was certainly refreshing in a space when any disagreement can warrant mixed responses.

I want to take all of this knowledge and thought forward with me into my future career regardless of what it may be in. For example, I will most likely join a consulting firm out of undergrad and I've been opened up to the idea of sustainable strategy. This means a lot personally because I potentially have power in helping the world become more climate conscious, especially if I can make it profitable to be so. Later in my life I am considering becoming involved with politics and I strongly believe that this class has shaped the way I think about policy and the different ways to get folks onboard with climate and environmentally conscious decisions. As I've also alluded to above, when I own my own firm, I have the power to choose sustainable directions and feel confident doing so, even if it's not always best for the bottom line. Finally, the thing which has not changed at all from the class is my desire to be a climate steward in my personal life. I still want to turn off light switches in common areas, take shorter showers, turn down the thermostat, and most importantly start new conversations with people about climate change. The class has equipped me with tools to use in conversations with climate skeptics and means of carrying the conversations to avoid confrontations. Likely the most valuable takeaway from the class is the desire and ability to talk about climate change. At

the end of the day, it's a numbers game and more people fighting climate change means more can get done.